



Building Friendships

*between people with and
people without disabilities*

**A Toolkit For Community
Recreation, Cultural,
and Faith Organizations**

The Arc of Massachusetts
217 South Street
Waltham, MA 02453

tel. 781-891-6270
www.arcmass.org



LIKE US ON FACEBOOK
facebook.com/thearcofmass



FOLLOW US ON TWITTER
twitter.com/thearcofmass



JOIN US ON INSTAGRAM
instagram.com/thearcofmass



The Arc
Massachusetts

This project is a partnership between
The Arc of Massachusetts and
the Massachusetts Department
of Developmental Services.

Table of Contents

A Note to You, the Reader	3	Your Pathway	
Introduction	4	Beyond Membership	35
05 Let's Begin with Definitions		36 The Story of Sean & Sean	
05 What Do We Mean by Your Role?		37 Friendship: Let's Get Started	
06 History Box		38 The Story of Matthew & Eric	
What Is Inclusion?		Friendship Hurdles	
(and what it isn't)	8	and Responses	40
09 An Important Note on Specialization		40 For Program Staff	
10 Six Principles of Inclusion		44 For Community Members	
11 A Story of Inclusion		48 For Organization Wide	
Your Pathway Toward Inclusion	12	Closing Remarks	52
12 Now Let's Get Started			
13 Story of Korynn & Daniel			
Inclusion Hurdles and Responses.....	14		
16 For Program Staff			
20 For Community Members			
24 For Organization Wide			
Continuing On Your			
Pathway Toward Inclusion	28		
28 A Story of Assimilation Potential			
30 The Story of Jesse & Jamie and Friends			
33 The Story of Norma & Phoebe			
34 History Box			

A FRIEND is someone who understands your past,
believes in your future, and accepts you just the
way you are. -*Unknown*

A Note to You, the Reader

You've picked up this toolkit, and we are glad you did. Perhaps the title intrigued you, or you have recently given more consideration to the term "inclusion", or you have a personal connection to someone with a disability. No matter your reason, now that we have your attention, you hold more power than anyone else to make an impact on friendships between persons with and without disabilities. More power and influence than their family members, support staff, or even the CEO of a nonprofit with a mission to support people with disabilities. You as a community member, who works or volunteers in recreation, civic, sport, faith, enrichment, wellness or community organizations, working with members of your community: you have that power.

You are an individual within a community whose outreach extends to every facet of every network you are a part of – churches, professions, volunteer organizations, sport teams, boards of directors, PTA, etc.. For this alone, you are a powerful resource based on the connections you have secured within your community. As a result, you can serve as an ambassador, making introductions of new connections and friendships.

Only you can offer the introduction to begin the connection that could lead to an authentic relationship and friendship that may begin to blossom. We invite you to take this journey to learn about your role in creating inclusive cultures within your community, where persons with and without a disability may experience all the benefits of lasting and authentic friendship.

-Lisa Drennan



Introduction

It is a sad fact that many people are pretty alone in this world: single parents, new college grads, people experiencing homelessness, teenagers, people in nursing homes, widows, widowers. This can be difficult to overcome, especially in a society where community membership is declining. In a variety of places, volunteer community engagement is shrinking, such as in churches, in civic clubs, and even bowling leagues.

We may not realize it, but this is especially true for most people with intellectual disabilities.

Why are they alone? Don't people with disabilities have people who take care of them? Well, yes, most of them do. Put yourself in their shoes: how would your life feel, if the people who care the most about you, are people who are **paid** to care about you? It's not the same. We all want people to care for us simply because we are who we are. How would it feel if there were no one who cares about you, just because you are you?

We realize that this group is very vulnerable. Maybe surrounded by people, but still alone.

But what can **you** do? This toolkit is addressed to people like you, who are staff or active members of organizations that offer opportunities for community and belonging through recreation, through civic engagement, through cultural enrichment, through neighborhood groups, or through faith communities. You can envision, plan, and implement ways to reach out and welcome people with disabilities into your organizations and world, and into the possibilities for friendship between people with and without disabilities.

You have more power and influence over this possibility than commissioners of human services, more power than governors, more power than people's own families. Belonging and friendship cannot be mandated. It cannot be bought. It can only be offered.

In this toolkit, we will provide practical ideas, strategies, and tactics that you can use to welcome people with disabilities into your organizations and lives. We will discuss how to overcome barriers and help people become full participants in their community. Finally, we will take our knowledge and learn how to invite people who have become fellow members to become more than that, to become **friends**.

You have that power: to make a significant difference in people's lives and communities.

Let's Begin with Definitions

INCLUSION: noun; the state of being included; authentic sense of belonging; can be a means to friendship as a goal. Includes people with and without disabilities together.

FRIENDSHIP: noun; the state of being friends; authentic sense of freely given companionship.

DISABILITY: noun; a physical, mental, cognitive, or developmental condition that creates a situation where a person needs adaptive supports in order to engage in certain tasks or actions or participate in typical daily activities and interactions.

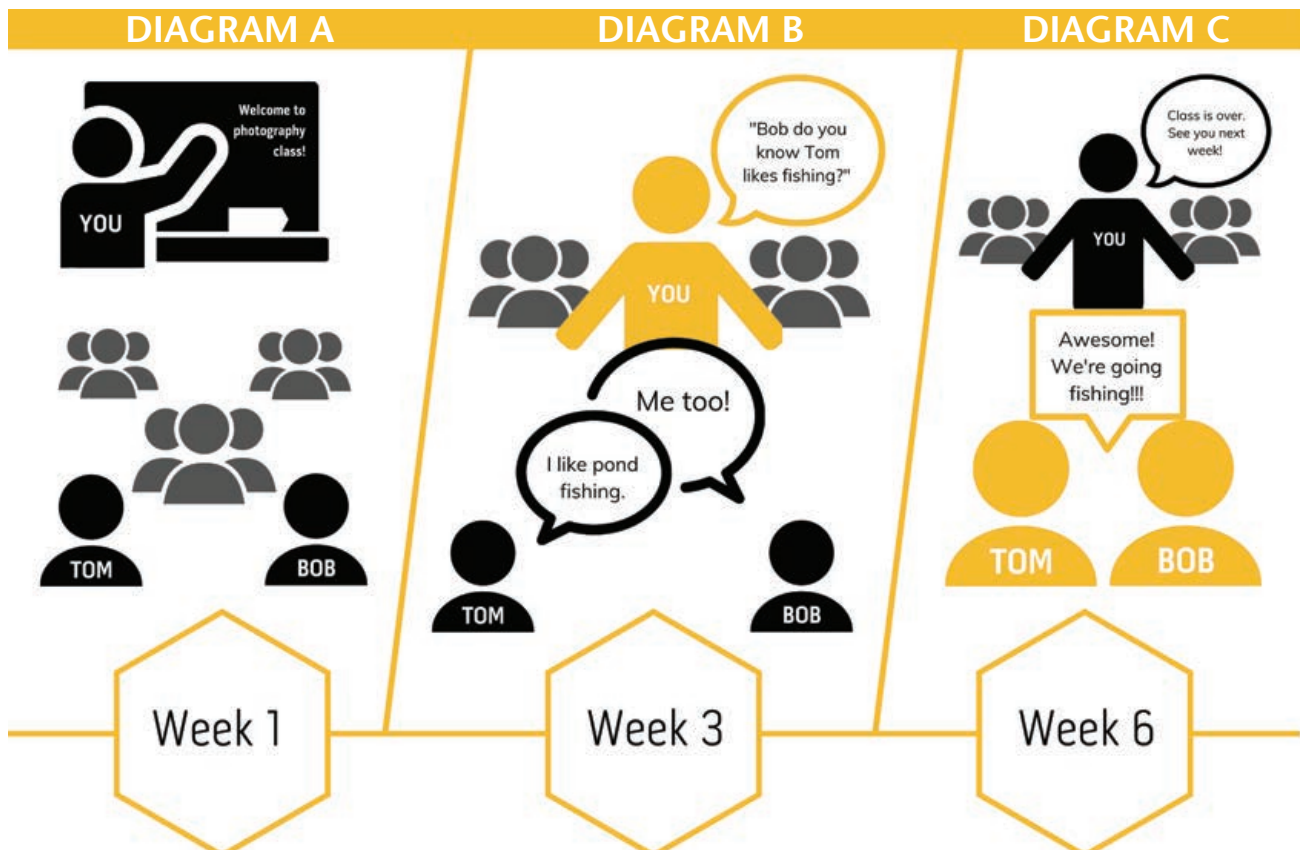
RECREATION*: noun; an activity done for enjoyment, is freely given, not what you get paid to do, not part of any contract. In other words, the *things we like to do* and, in this booklet, we will use this term to include any of the following.



* A note on language, we will be using this general term "recreation" throughout the book, to represent all of these aspects of community life.

What Do We Mean by Your Role?

You are teaching a photography class where Tom and Bob are students (**diagram A**). Tom has developmental disabilities; Bob does not. Both Bob and Tom enjoy country music and fishing. You introduce Bob to Tom, facilitating a connection that may lead to a friendship outside of this class. (**diagram B**) You are aware of an upcoming Country Fest that is looking for volunteers to help run the raffle table. Bob and Tom end up volunteering together and even working together to obtain donations from local businesses for the raffle table. As your class nears the end of the session, you notice that Bob and Tom are meeting more and more outside of class. (**diagram C**) You can change lives – enhance lives!



History Box

People need and benefit from friends, belonging, community membership-What could be more obvious? Why doesn't it happen all the time?

Well, there is a sad story behind this.

We as human beings often seem to put distance between "us" and "them." It has happened to racial groups, social classes, and foreign populations in just about every society in history, and it is certainly true in our own society today. This distancing takes the form of segregation, exile, walls erected, or (more subtly) less interaction or one-sided interaction. This has unfortunately happened to people with intellectual disabilities.

A hundred years ago, this was really extreme, pushed by an ideology called eugenics, which for decades was a totally dominant line of thinking. The idea behind it was that all important characteristics about human beings were asserted to be hereditary: intelligence, probable success, even moral character. The eugenicists proposed, based on that erroneous thinking, that the way to improve society would be to make sure people with "bad genes" could not have children. In Germany during World War II, that line of thinking led to the mass murder of people with disabilities. In most states in the U.S. (and several other "advanced" societies), that same line of thinking was the rationale for sterilizing tens of thousands of people with intellectual disabilities between 1907 and 1970. It was also the major rationale for segregating hundreds of thousands of people in institutions across America, during that same period.

Starting in the 1970s, there was a huge reaction against these awful, dehumanizing institutions, and they have almost disappeared. People with intellectual disabilities now live with families or in small group settings throughout every town and city. These were revolutionary changes, and a very good thing for us all.

But there is still a strong residue of segregation. People are *in* community, but not always *of* community. We still often act as if people with intellectual disabilities should be "with their own kind," and we see this unconscious attitude expressed in "special" (in fact segregated) programs in recreation, in worship, and in many schools. We may see little everyday ways, such as the expectation that people in community organizations would be "taken care of" by paid staff, instead of welcomed into full membership and participation and possible friendship, by all of their members.

That "with their own kind" mindset is still pervasive within most communities, within many service staff, and within many people with disabilities themselves. It is not mean-spirited; it is usually unintentional and even subconscious. But it limits people's life opportunities. This toolkit is designed to overcome that limitation, in ourselves and within our communities. Overcoming that limitation will be to the ultimate benefit not only of people with intellectual disabilities, but for the ultimate benefit of us all.



Recreation's purpose is not to kill time, but to make life, not to keep a person occupied, but to keep them refreshed; not to offer an escape from life, but to provide a discovery of life.

– unattributed

Often organizations like yours are the best possible route to an authentic friendship.

We participate in recreational opportunities with others because of common interests. People make connections with others based on commonality of interests and beliefs; this is the foundation, the platform upon which we build.

Out of all the ways we spend our time, recreational activities present the perfect building blocks on which opportunities and foundations for friendship can be built.

Why? Generally speaking, work and school environments focus on intelligence, productivity, and measurements, creating separation and labels. Recreation is meant to be fun. **Everybody** possesses the ability to have fun, feel fun, experience fun. It's what people **choose** to do with their time; it's where people **want** to spend their time.

Community and belonging: why don't they happen all the time? People with disabilities have been historically segregated. This behavior has worked its way into our collective mindset of how recreation should be, where we assume people with and without disabilities will be separate. Additionally, people with disabilities and their staff believe there are special programs for them and that's where they have traditionally participated. As a result, even you or our collective community assumed that "these people" participated with "their own." Special almost always means segregated.

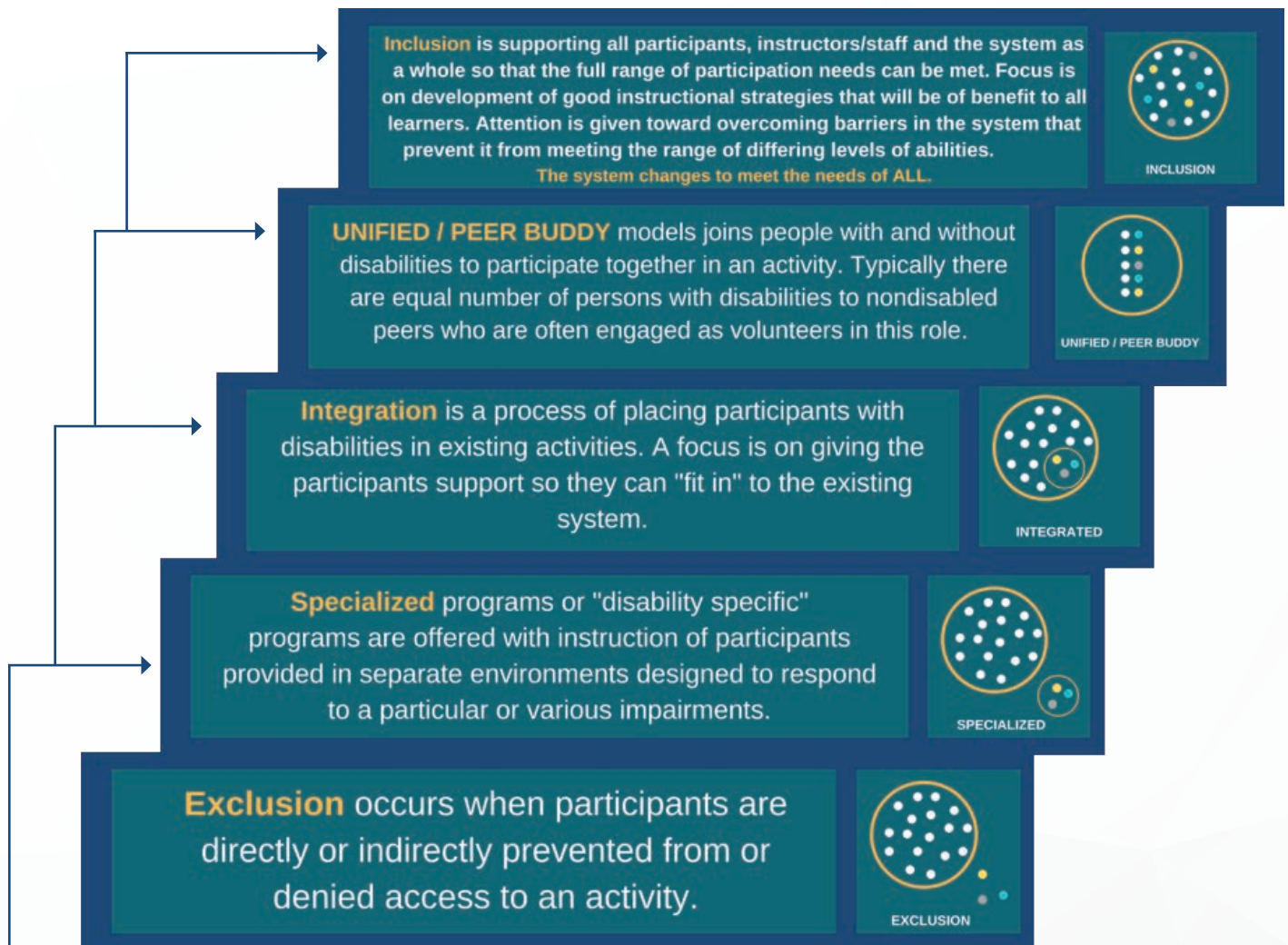
The purpose of this toolkit is to eliminate that default thinking and the stigma it creates.

INCLUSION is not a strategy to help people fit into the systems and structures which exist in our societies; it is about transforming those systems and structures to make it better for everyone.

– Diane Richler,
Past President,
Inclusion
International

What is Inclusion? (and what it isn't)

This chart shows us different ways persons with disabilities can participate in recreational, enrichment or faith-based activities in relationship to their peers without disabilities.



Source: *Methods of Participation*, MERGE Inclusion Consulting: www.mergeconsulting.org

An Important Note on Specialization

It may sometimes be necessary to offer specialization in an inclusive program in order to customize an individual's involvement so that they are able to be a successful participant. This does not imply either exclusion or a segregated ("special") group. Specialized supports are created by building in, as necessary, accommodations and modifications. In other words, our guiding principles should be always customize, never segregate! Here is an example of this principle being applied in a summer camp setting.

Every Chipmunk is a Horseback Rider by Jack Yates

Ben Becker's Camp Nassau, near Albany, New York, was a typical day camp in many ways. About three hundred campers came each day, and they were organized into age groups. The ten-year-old boys were the Woodchucks; the nine-year-old girls were the Dolphins; the twelve-year-old girls were the Chipmunks. Through the day, the groups engaged in activities typical of a day camp: swimming, canoeing, crafts, nature lore, horseback riding, and so on.

One thing about the camp, however, was not so typical. Its owner and director, Ben Becker, decided that it would be a good learning experience for everyone to recruit campers who were children with physical or intellectual disabilities. He ensured that 5-10% of the campers in any given week were children with disabilities, and he even gave scholarships as necessary to make sure. Thus, when the Chipmunks went horseback riding, not every Chipmunk could just jump on a horse and ride; and not every Chipmunk could learn as quickly or as easily as every other Chipmunk.

For instance, in the group of thirty Chipmunks, one was a girl who was blind. When she went horseback riding with the Chipmunks, another girl rode on a horse next to her, to call over instructions and encouragement. Another of the Chipmunks was a girl with intellectual disability and with cerebral palsy, and she had limited control especially on one side of her body. So, when she went horseback riding with the Chipmunks, she had a more secure type of belt as well as another girl riding at her side on another horse, and sometimes at a curve one of the counselors would run along at the other side of the horse, like a spotter in gymnastics. Another Chipmunk was a girl who had no effective use of her legs. So, when she went horseback riding with the Chipmunks, one of the bigger girls who was already a good rider would ride in back of her in the saddle, holding her shoulders to make sure she would stay on the horse.

We human service visitors were very impressed with Ben Becker's camp, but it was only looking back on it that we realized that his camp operated under a rule—every twelve-year-old girl is a Chipmunk, and every Chipmunk is a horseback rider. Even though they did not state it under a rule, that was the principle which guided the camp.

Back in the "bad old days," human services operated under a rule that some people are horseback riders, and some aren't. It's a shame, really, since horseback riding is such a fine experience, but some people just don't have it in them to be horseback riders. In contrast, in our services in these more progressive days, most programs have a more enlightened rule. We have high expectations for all our campers, and our rule now is that every Chipmunk will be a horseback rider someday. In the meantime, we'll hire the best teachers and the gentlest horses for our "special" group of future horseback riders, working with them patiently and intensively until, some day (we know it will come!), they will be able to become horseback riders as a member of the Chipmunks.

Doesn't sound so bad. But at Ben Becker's camp, they had a different rule – every twelve-year-old girl is a Chipmunk, and every Chipmunk is a horseback rider. What varies is **not** who is a horseback rider and who isn't; **every** Chipmunk is a horseback rider. And what varies is not when someone will attain horseback rider status; every Chipmunk is a horseback rider, now, **today**. The only thing that varies is what help a person needs to stay in the saddle.

Six Principles of Inclusion

Inclusion is **not** a program, it is **not** a staff member, and it is **not** an event. Inclusion is the **intentional** work an organization commits to ensuring that **all** belong. When an organization commits to creating a culture of inclusion, it makes systemic changes that prepare the organization to welcome, engage, and support persons with disabilities to be valued participants in their community. Embracing these six Principles of Inclusion is the foundation of creating a culture of inclusion at your recreation, cultural, or civic organization.



ORGANIZATIONAL COMMITMENT

ALL stakeholders have a responsibility and role in inclusion.

Resources and support provided at ALL levels to carry out their role in inclusion.



MEANINGFUL PARTICIPATION

Focus is not just on physical proximity, instead attention is on creating environments where everyone is participating together.

It is the understanding that everyone has something of value to contribute.



MEET PEOPLE WHERE THEY ARE AT

We change the systems to support the person by making individualized accommodations and modifications.

We understand that success is individualized and may be different for different activities.



WORKING TOWARDS FULL INCLUSION

Means supporting a person to be as independent as possible in the least restrictive environment.

Adaptive or specialized programs are used as a gateway toward full inclusion, not the end of the road.



LET'S GET TO SUCCESS!

A change of perspective or approach where, when given a challenge, instead of thinking "no we can't" we think "how can we" make this work?

Tap into all resources to explore how we can get to "YES".



EVERYONE HAS A RIGHT TO BELONG

To be welcomed, engaged and supported – there are so many reasons and benefits to opening your doors to ALL types of diversity.

The ADA ensures that persons with disabilities have a legal right to participate.

Source: *Six Principles of Inclusion*, MERGE Inclusion Consulting: www.mergeconsulting.org

A Story of Inclusion

A town recreation program has provided “Special Rec” programs including “Autism Swim” and a “Buddy Basketball League” for years, created specifically for people with disabilities. In other words, they were segregated. Recently at the request of family members seeking to have their children participate in activities alongside their peers from the community, the leadership staff started exploring how to be more inclusive in all of their programs. After attending a conference session on how to build an inclusive recreation program, their leadership team started the process of establishing their initiative and planning for how they would help their organization move toward an authentic inclusive culture.

Their program has now made incremental steps along their inclusion journey. They have worked to train all of their staff on inclusion principles and techniques and have implemented the recommended strategies. They have also worked to update the language and imagery on all of their marketing and online collateral to raise awareness of their inclusion initiative, accurately depicting all dimensions of diversity, and to provide information to families on accessing inclusive offerings. One of their next steps is to hire an Inclusion Specialist. This position will serve as a support role to provide resources, training and instruction; working to educate all staff in the program.

They are proud of how far they’ve come on this path yet recognize they have further to go on their journey.



 Let's think...

What does inclusion look like in your setting?

Where are you on your inclusion journey?

If you believe in inclusion you make it work – **let us show you how.**



You can get help in the process of customizing these practices to fit your program.

Visit mergeconsulting.org for additional information.

Your Pathway Toward Inclusion

NOW LET'S GET STARTED

You can hardly get to *friendship* without first taking the path through *inclusion*. Many organizations have made inclusion a priority, and more than likely they experienced some hurdles along the way. In fact, there are common barriers that recreation and community organizations have experienced. There are also commonly understood best practices that transcend all programs, and some will relate to you. By sharing these hurdles and best practices, we can provide context as to how others have included people with disabilities and helped them build friendships.

We welcome you to take this journey on the inclusion path where we will show you that there are practices that people and organizations have found effective in overcoming those hurdles.

As you navigate through these pages, keep in mind that this is a toolkit of suggestions (as opposed to telling you what to do or completing a checklist; this is more about your goals and the movement toward those goals). You will need to customize these to be effective tools and resources for you, your team, and your organization to embrace and implement. On your pathway, take the time to pause at places that resonate with you and keep coming back as you continue your own journey of creating a culture of inclusion in your community program. In other words, if your end goal is to help people with and without disabilities to create friendships, this section would be the best possible recommendation for that goal to be achieved.

NOW YOU ARE READY TO BEGIN YOUR PATHWAY TOWARD INCLUSION



Inclusion Means WITH, Not Just IN.

A Story of Korynn & Daniel

Meet Korynn and Daniel from Middleboro, Massachusetts. They met in the eighth grade and immediately recognized that they enjoyed each other's company. Shortly after, they ended up in chorus together and participated in track together after school. That's where their friendship really started to blossom. Practicing together, cheering each other on, and having that common bond through participation in something they both loved really helped to strengthen their friendship. They soon started getting together outside of school, and like all teenagers, texted regularly and became "selfie" experts, capturing all their fun and memories.

Korynn explains what having Daniel as a friend means to her: "Seeing Daniel is the best part of my day. We laugh and talk and have so much fun. It's something I carry with me for the rest of the day." She adds, "When I have exciting news, he's the first person I want to tell; when I'm sad about something, he's the first person I want to talk to."

Daniel is equally grateful for his friendship with Korynn: "She likes me, and I like her. I feel happy when we are together; we are always laughing".

A sign of a strong friendship is when the bond continues outside of the planned activities, and beyond the role of fellow student and teammates. In March 2020, when the COVID-19 pandemic hit, resulting in shutting down school and extracurricular activities, and physical distancing became mandated, Korynn and Daniel got creative on how they could continue their social connection and friendship. Sending each other videos, texting, and checking in on Zoom became a way to keep connected daily, but Daniel really went next level for a special occasion and planned a "drive-by," complete with balloons, music, and physically distanced well wishes for Korynn.

As for the future, when the restrictions from Coronavirus are lifted, Korynn hopes to have her driver's license, which will give them more options for getting together. She is looking forward to going out to lunch or to the movies with Daniel and when asked what he would like to do first, Daniel's response was "Go to the beach!"





START
HERE

On Your Pathway Toward Inclusion



You are here traveling on your journey
toward inclusion.

Some reading this toolkit may be brand new to the concept of inclusion, while others may have some background and experience but are looking to broaden their knowledge and improve their practice.

No matter where you are with your “start here” space, it is likely that you either have faced or will face road bumps or hurdles. Some of these hurdles may be faced by staff directly supporting the programs, by those with disabilities seeking to participate or their families, or by the administration or your organization as a whole. The hurdles experienced generally fall into three categories: logistical hurdles, policy hurdles, or mindset hurdles.

We will look at these hurdles through different lenses, differentiated by whom they affect most directly (staff, individuals/families, administration/organizations). By sharing with you these hurdles and best practices, we can provide you with some of the concrete ways others have overcome these hurdles, have included people with disabilities, and have helped people with disabilities to build new friendships.

As with any growth cycle, the pathway to inclusion never ends. You encounter hurdles, learn, grow, overcome, and then you take a “breather” and know that it’s not the end of your work. It’s always evolving with additional layers of new or recurring hurdles emerging. As your inclusion initiative strengthens, you are positioning yourself and your programming to help create the foundation of an authentic friendship between a person with and a person without a disability.

Let’s start down that pathway.



Hurdles Encountered by Program Staff*

We recognize there are hurdles that are, or will be, experienced by staff who have a responsibility to run programs or offerings for our community. Hurdles generally fall into categories which may present as or be solved by:

POLICIES

MINDSET

LOGISTICS

**The term "staff" could refer to counselors, coaches, volunteers, instructors, or anyone who is directly involved with running programs or offerings and also interfaces with the community membership.*

STAFF INEXPERIENCE

Lack of training for staff; those without experience not feeling confident to work with people with disabilities.

"What if they have behaviors? I don't know how deal with that."

MISINFORMED/ QUICK TO DISMISS

Program staff have inaccurate perceptions around what including people with disabilities might be like or fall into negative stereotyping.

"It's a safety issue; we shouldn't jeopardize the whole program"

"We've always run the program this way. If we make a change, it will be too difficult for everyone."

TOOLS NOT BEING UTILIZED

Tools such as sensory kits, fidget toys, tips, or direction sheets are available for team members but not utilized.

"I can't see how those toys are really going to help in this situation."

"I didn't know that fact sheet on dealing with children with autism was there. I never saw it before"

STAFF MINDSET ON FEELING UNQUALIFIED

How a staff member perceives their ability to include, and work with, persons with disabilities.

*"I've never worked with children like that."
"How do I communicate with a person who I can't understand?"
"I don't have that background or experience to run this program."*

MISUNDERSTANDING INCLUSION

The staff, volunteers, and all involved in the program do not understand what inclusion truly is and feel their efforts to offer a specialized (which really means segregated) class is enough.

"We are an inclusive organization; we have a special needs swim program."

UNCLEAR EXPECTATIONS

Program staff are not aware that their organization is inclusive of persons with disabilities and do not believe it is part of their job responsibility.

"I wasn't told in the job interview I would have to work with special needs children, and it's not in the job description."

RIGID STAFF MINDSET ABOUT THEIR ROLE

A staff member's attitude may be self-limiting about their role and responsibilities.

*"This is the way we've always done it; we can't make those changes for this one kid."
"Figuring this all out takes too much time. We aren't behavior specialists."
"It's too much work. Shouldn't there be a special program for them?"*

OVER-RELIANCE ON INCLUSION STAFF

A program has a designated inclusion staff or someone on staff with special education experience. All other staff don't see the need to learn how to work with "these children."

*"Get the inclusion staff to take care of them; we'll just focus on the 'normal' children."
"It's too much work. Shouldn't there be a special program for them?"*

Overcoming Hurdles: Responses to Support Program Staff

Explore these tips and strategies to provide program staff the tools and confidence to welcome, support, and engage persons with disabilities into the programs or offerings provided.

CREATE PARTNERSHIP

Collaborate with organizations committed to inclusion of persons with disabilities (The Arc, human service agencies, etc.).

ADHERE TO CLEAR POLICIES RELATED TO INCLUSION

Implement policies to ensure all staff embrace commitments and measures of inclusion, replacing staff as necessary (e.g., offer specialized training, address in the evaluation process, HR involvement).

INVITE STAFF TO PARTICIPATE

Inviting staff to attend an existing inclusion event/program can help them to gain and build confidence. Encourage their efforts. By observing inclusion in action, they see it's possible.

HAVE PROCEDURES TO INVITE CRITIQUE

Welcome looking at ways/policies to improve inclusion (e.g., intake process, evaluate how tours are given).

CREATE AN INCLUSION ADVISORY BOARD FOR YOUR ORGANIZATION

Ensure all levels of staff are represented and involved as members.

SET CLEAR EXPECTATIONS FOR STAFF

Put forth expectations in your job description, interview, onboarding (specific to that role), and evaluation processes. This allows for hiring staff who are open-minded, thus building a foundation toward a culture of inclusion.

OFFER CUSTOMIZED & SUSTAINABLE INCLUSION TRAININGS

Focus on disability strategies and principles. Should be offered for all levels of staff specific to their role and responsibilities. To be most effective, have a strong focus on implementation of strategies to become part of procedure which builds independence and culture.

SET EXPECTATIONS FOR PARTICIPATING IN YOUR OFFERING

Carefully weigh the pros and cons of accommodations and modifications to help all persons to be able to participate equitably.

IMPLEMENT INCLUSION STRATEGIES PROGRAM-WIDE

Identify and provide training to all staff members on techniques and strategies like using a visual schedule or reviewing expectations.

PRACTICE WHAT YOU PREACH

Setting a good example is everything. Are you hiring a diverse workforce?

Do you actively seek to welcome, hire, and support staff members with disabilities?

BUILD PROGRAMS FOR ALL AGE GROUPS

Start young: to see the benefits and set the expectations as your membership grows throughout the years.

KNOW YOUR CHAMPIONS

Who on the team “gets” and practices inclusion naturally? Celebrate them, use their examples as a model, and have them coach and support others on your team.

Hurdles Encountered by Community Members* Participating in (or Seeking to Participate in) Programming

We recognize there are hurdles that are specific to a person with disabilities and their family members and support network, as they seek access to programming. However, there may also be hurdles experienced or created by members without disabilities and/or their family members.

Hurdles generally fall into categories which may present as or be solved by:

**POLICIES,
MINDSET, LOGISTICS**

**The term "COMMUNITY MEMBERS" could include persons with and without disabilities who participate in programming, as well as their family members and/or their direct support professionals.*

FEAR OF DISCLOSURE

If families are concerned that their child might be turned away from programming or be stigmatized, they may opt to hold back key information about their family member in an effort to avoid this. They may not realize that it could be more detrimental for their family member by not sharing necessary information with the staff team.

"If I mentioned that she sometimes feels overwhelmed and has meltdowns, they might not accept her into the program. It's best to just get her in, then if something happens, we'll deal with it."

NO LOCAL INCLUSIVE PROGRAMS

When not enough programs are inclusive in their nature, often family members have to travel to other towns where they are offered. This distance creates hurdles that prevent connecting with other community members.

"We had to travel over an hour to find a camp that is inclusive, but then she always felt like an outsider as she didn't know any of the children."

PROGRESSION & GROWTH IS LIMITED DUE TO FEAR

Some family members may want specialized programs only. They may have had negative experiences in the past or just cannot "imagine" their family member being successful in a fully inclusive model.

"He loves robotics and it would be great if he could join that camp, but I can't put my son into a typical program. What if he is teased or won't fit in with the others?"

COST PROHIBITIVE

Whether perceived or actual, family members are concerned that the cost to attend will be exorbitant.

"If my family member needs extra help in this program, the cost will be too high or I'll be asked to provide a 1:1 aide which we can't afford."

COMPETITIVE NATURE OF SOME SPORTS

Sport-based organizations may be competitive in the way they are offered, with a focus on winning.

"I used to play for this league when I was younger and now I'm a coach. It's always been this way; people won't like the change to let in children with disabilities."

FAMILIES DON'T FEEL WELCOMED

Your marketing materials or social media don't indicate that people with disabilities are welcomed, or not everyone on the team is aware of your inclusion initiative and might misinform interested families.

"I wasn't sure when I looked online if my daughter with Down syndrome could participate, then when I stopped by, the person at the front desk said they didn't think they had programs like that."

OBJECTIONS BY SOME MEMBERS

Non-disabled members of your organization (and/or their families) may object, question, or make complaints about others with disabilities participating alongside them.

"Why do those children get special privileges?"

"What if they are aggressive or have behaviors? They could hurt my child."

"When she's in the class, the instructor will have to keep slowing down to give her special attention and it can ruin the experience for all of us in the class."

FAMILY AND PROGRAM EXPECTATIONS DON'T ALIGN

Barriers may arise when expectations are not clearly defined for both community members and the program. Clarity and follow-up are important in keeping good communication and building a team.

"We should have asked the parents to review the schedule with him before coming to camp each day."

"Just because she hit one of the staff members shouldn't mean she can't go on the field trip."

"As a direct support professional, I can just leave Janice there during her Zumba class and take off to run my own personal errands."

Overcoming Hurdles: Responses to Support Community Members Participating and Their Families

Explore these tips and strategies to provide individuals with disabilities and their families a welcoming and supportive environment where they can access opportunities that can help them become valued members of the community. Recognize that members without disabilities and their families have a key role in creating a culture of inclusion.

IMPLEMENT A WELCOMING INTAKE PROCESS

This first step is crucial to building a “teamwork” approach and to knowing what can be most supportive to this person.

BUILD MEMBER-TO-MEMBER SUPPORT

If a new member or their family may be struggling, then link them up with someone who has experienced success. This can be arranged either ahead of time, or in the moment when specific situations occur, where another family can relate with a positive suggestion.

CREATE A CULTURE OF (SAFE) RISK TAKING

Encourage experimentation or try new approaches and see what happens! Growth through inclusion often has slow change and takes patience from all involved. Count all small accomplishments as a win!

MAKE INDIVIDUALIZED ACCOMMODATIONS

Work with persons with disabilities and their support systems to identify and implement reasonable accommodations ensuring successful participation.

CREATE AN INCLUSION ADVISORY BOARD

Ensure persons with and without disabilities and their families are represented and involved as members.

ENCOURAGE EFFECTIVE LEARNING

Providing opportunities for participants, family members, and caregivers to be heard provides an effective way for both the struggles and the benefits of inclusion to be understood. Replicate and emulate this practice and always lead with a caring heart. Developing a comfortable way for members to speak up may increase a teamwork approach to resolving conflicts and celebrating achievements.

OFFER & PROMOTE PROGRESSIVE MODELS OF PARTICIPATION*

(REFER TO PG 8)

Build programming to promote greater independence while always working toward full inclusion. Ask families/individuals who experience success to share their story.

SET MEMBER EXPECTATIONS

Set procedures to address intolerant behavior on the part of other members. This process involves education, policies, and procedures.

JOIN THEIR TEAM TO PROBLEM SOLVE TOGETHER

Build rapport with families or support staff to increase trust and confidence. Reach out to them to provide suggestions and approaches that will help this person to be successful in your program.

Hurdles Encountered by Program Leadership, Administration or your Organization As a Whole

We recognize that there are hurdles that may be experienced by administrative staff, leadership teams, board members, and other community members.

MISPERCEPTION OF FINANCIAL IMPLICATIONS

Often the thought of committing to inclusion brings the fear of what it might cost an organization.

"If we open up to all kinds of disabilities, we will have to provide 1:1 care and we aren't equipped for that"

"We don't have specialists to be able to deal with those children and can't afford to bring them on"

MARKETING AND PROMOTION NOT REPRESENTING INCLUSIVE PRINCIPLES

Inaccuracy or mistakes in marketing and promotion turn off the disability community and/or cause complaints. Includes use of inappropriate terminology in social media posts and unauthentic stock photos or images. Stories about program participants with disabilities are sensationalized or used as "inspiration porn" which is the portrayal of people with disabilities as inspirational solely, or in part, based on their disability.

"As a board member I am proud to share with my colleagues that this organization allows 'the autistic' and other 'mentally challenged people' to join."

CONCERN OF OVERSATURATION POTENTIAL

A belief if an organization offers more programming or they market too heavily, then the percentage of members with disabilities will grow to be disproportionate to the surrounding community.

"If we do too good of a job with this inclusion program, then the disabled from all over will all come here, and it will be more than we can handle."

**see Assimilation Potential on page 28*

NOT FULLY COMMITTED ORGANIZATION-WIDE

You are providing minimal support and resources toward an inclusion initiative as a means to “check it off the list.”

“We are an inclusive organization; we have two special needs programs for children with autism.”

“We have an Inclusion Specialist who takes care of all those requests and interests.”

FEAR OF LEGAL ACTIONS

An organization may be hesitant to welcome persons with disabilities if they believe it could bring upon potential legal actions if they don’t “do something right” or have buildings and grounds that are not fully accessible. Of note, in regard to Americans with Disabilities Act (ADA) civil cases, focus has generally been on access for physical disabilities, but recently, more and more are around participation of persons with hidden or intellectual disabilities.

“I’ve heard of a program that got sued because someone with a disability wasn’t able to get into their pool. It was a big headache for them.”

“I mean, we want to be accommodating and all, but our building is old and not up to ADA standards. If we promote that we are inclusive, it could cause us legal issues and end up costing us a fortune.”

PROFESSIONAL DEVELOPMENT & TRAINING NOT CONSIDERED FOR THIS LEVEL

An assumption that if inclusion training is offered for program managers and direct level staff, then that is thorough enough. Organizational commitment is not developed, and leadership or administrative staff are not knowledgeable about inclusion and therefore not as effective in voicing considerations for budget, strategic plans, and other goals relative to inclusion.

“Yeah, I don’t really know a lot about disabilities., We provide training for the camp staff, so they know how to deal with those children. Isn’t that enough?”

WORK FORCE NOT REPRESENTATIVE OF DISABILITIES

There is not a committed effort to recruit, hire, and train persons with disabilities into the organization’s workforce. Or, if there are jobs held by people with disabilities, they are generally menial, are created positions, or they are asked to be volunteers in the position.

“We are so fortunate to have an employee with Down syndrome. Cyndi is great at folding towels; we are glad we found a task for her to do while she is here.”

Overcoming Hurdles: Responses to Support Program Leadership, Administration or Your Organization as a Whole

Explore these tips and strategies to provide administrative staff, leadership teams, board members, and other community members with the tools to build a foundation supporting an organizational commitment to inclusion so that all are welcomed, engaged and supported to be successful.

CARVE OUT A PLACE FOR INCLUSION

Inclusion should be considered in your budgeting process and strategic planning (e.g., set a percentage of the budget to accessible capital improvements). Also, incorporate an inclusion lens in your mission, goals, evaluation process, and networking.

CREATE AN INCLUSION ADVISORY BOARD

Ensure persons with and without disabilities and their families are represented and involved as members.

EMBRACE INCLUSION PRINCIPLES IN MARKETING

Review all marketing collateral, print, and media to be aligned with disability recommended terminology and inclusion philosophies. Seek to obtain authentic photos from existing programs reflecting what is offered. Focus on accomplishments of members, avoid using terminology that would imply “overcoming” a disability or other phrases that don’t align with disability etiquette. Consider your mission and guiding principles, and review them to ensure they are inclusive in their message and nature.

UNDERSTAND THE ADA

Commit to compliance with the Americans with Disabilities Act and knowledge of rights. Consider both physical and programmatic accessibility.

ADOPT AN INCLUSIVE LENS ON ORGANIZATIONAL DEVELOPMENT AND GROWTH

All new buildings, existing renovations, and projects should have a Universal Design lens considered in the planning phase. Inclusion should be considered for organization wide program and events as well.

CREATE SPACE FOR DISCUSSION

At every level of your organization, dedicated communication and space is imperative to regularly discuss inclusion initiatives and progress. In other words, “it’s on the agenda” for all meetings.

INVOLVE PEOPLE WITH DISABILITIES THROUGHOUT YOUR ORGANIZATION

Involve people with disabilities as valued members of boards, committees, and as decisions makers. Ratios represent the community.

COLLABORATE WITH COMMUNITY ORGANIZATIONS

Reach out to organizations and agencies within your community that support people with disabilities. Through this, you are connecting with the community you seek to support, while also creating access to additional resources for your development of procedures, trainings, and policies.

DEFINE PROGRAMS CLEARLY

Understand the elements of and differences between the models of participation:
Specialized, Integrated, Unified, Authentic Inclusion (see page 8).

Spell out the supports offered and expectations of participants in descriptive marketing materials.

MEASURE PROGRESS

Survey and/or measure goals.
Explore and execute how to measure and judge success of inclusion in programs (example: collect testimonials, survey, etc.).

A Story of Assimilation Potential



Mary, who is 24, was interested in taking Zumba at her local YMCA. Mary has autism and ADHD, and initially her mother had concerns about how she would fit in, or if the experience would be positive, especially given that she really struggled with social skills in group settings. All the fitness staff at this Y recently participated in an inclusion training focused on providing instruction that is welcoming, engaging, and supportive of members with disabilities.



EXCLUSION

As an organization they had recognized that most of their fitness classes were “Exclusive” in their nature.

Mary and her mother met with the Zumba instructor Tanya to discuss specific concerns and strategies that would be helpful for Mary to be successful. After a few weeks, it was clear that Mary was starting to get the swing of it, was becoming more comfortable, and was even starting to interact with others in the class. Tanya was feeling very positive about Mary’s participation and with her own confidence in being more inclusive in her practices. This was the first time she had someone in her class that she knew of with a disability. Another member of the class had a brother with Down syndrome who also loved Zumba. After seeing how successful Mary was in the class, she invited her brother Andy to join in as well. Tanya and the class welcomed him with open arms.



INCLUSION

This class now became an example of being an inclusive model where persons with and without disabilities are participating together.

As the months went on, Mary (and her mother) started to share their experience with their friends and others from the group home where Mary just started living. The staff of the group home became very interested, thinking about others that their agency served who would also enjoy a class like this. Fast forward a few months and Tanya is feeling overwhelmed. In her recent class, two different group homes showed up to join the class, each with three people they supported. Tanya didn’t know anything about them ahead of

time. One group came in 15 minutes late and was quite disruptive to the class. Shortly after, a woman from the other group started to yell out loudly when a class member danced into “her space,” and Tanya noticed that the staff member accompanying her was not in the class; he had left to go walk on the treadmill. Several of the other class members appeared to be getting frustrated and had voiced concerns that they were going to start looking for another class. Tanya had noticed that many of her “regulars” hadn’t been to class in awhile. What has happened? When a class that is “doing inclusion” creates a “buzz” among the



This class now has exceeded the assimilation potential of the group - the number of persons with disabilities has become disproportionate to the general membership that was before the class opened up to being inclusive – effectively going backward such that the non-disabled members of the group find it harder and harder to welcome and fully assimilate members with disabilities into the group.

disability community, especially if there are not many inclusive options available, there is a potential that “word of mouth” increased participation can become overwhelming and essentially change the dynamic of the offering. The welcome may be worn out by the existing program and non-disabled participants may opt out, putting the program at risk for transforming into what we term an integrated or specialized model (see page 8). This also causes a barrier for the community to see everyone as an individual, perpetuates stigma, and, if left unaddressed, may cause irreparable damage to the organization’s inclusion initiative. The bottom line is, in an inclusion model class, the proportions should align with the general population’s percentage of disabled to non-disabled participants. Roughly speaking, 20% of the group being people with disabilities might be the maximum in order for there be enough of a preponderance of more welcomers than people to be welcomed.

WHAT IF YOU FIND YOUR PROGRAM FALLS INTO THIS? WHAT CAN YOU DO?

First: take a deep breath and know this is just a hurdle in the continued path toward inclusion. Revisit the strategies or “responses” from the previous pages and initiate a plan on how to rein it back in toward being an inclusive model again. Generally, when this occurs, it could be due to a lack of options available for inclusive programming. That’s a good thing, as it tells us we need more inclusion! Evaluate your organization’s capacity to open up more classes to the inclusion model and explore if an additional specialized or integrated class might be necessary as a means to provide that “step up” component of support to those seeking to participate in a particular activity that aren’t quite ready for the full inclusive model yet. Collaborate with other towns or programs and advocate for their push toward being more inclusive in their practices. Become a role model for them, providing support toward their journey.

When more of our communities become inclusive, then we are creating a shift toward more inclusive communities!

The Story of Jesse & Jamie and Friends

Jesse had friends, friends like Jamie and Kyle, Adam and Kelham, friends who would come over to his house to go swimming, listen to music together, and partake in the shenanigans that go along with a sleepover.

Jamie Becker met Jesse when they were in seventh grade science class together. She started talking to him, and even though he was nonverbal, they did not have trouble understanding each other. "I felt like I could communicate with him by not even saying a word, we just got each other," shares Jamie as she recounts the first day meeting him. In fact, later that year, Jamie's teacher had to move her seat because she was always talking too much to Jesse.

It was not too long before Jamie and Jesse started hanging out together outside of school. "I would bring Jesse a newly burnt CD of all the music I liked and we would get a kick out of listening to them together," Jamie shared. "A favorite memory with Jesse was when we (Jesse, and their friend Kyle) got dressed up for Halloween and handed out candy to the neighborhood kids. Afterward we watched scary movies together. It was so much fun.



Jamie's recollection of how she shared with her parents about meeting a new friend, was similar to that of Adam, a friend from elementary school who is described by Jesse's mother Marianne in her memoir, *Knowing Jesse*:

He made friends, too, Adam and Kelham, neither one the sensitive type you'd think would be attracted to a nonverbal kid in a wheelchair.

Adam told his mother there was a kid in his class who hated to color as much as he did and could they have him over for a visit? A few weeks later he asked his mom, "what does nonverbal mean?" His mother told him. Adam was puzzled: "But Jesse can talk, people just don't listen." Adam's mom was shocked when she met Jesse. Adam hadn't mentioned the wheelchair. It just wasn't important to him, as was the mutual hatred of coloring. When Jesse came over to visit, Adam and his brother, Derek, included him in their boisterous games, Jesse shrieking with laughter as they





Jesse Cooper (1987-2005)

maneuvered his wheelchair in a dizzying game of tag. Later they became bowling buddies one day a week at the local lanes, Jesse pushing the ball down a chute that fit over his wheelchair, Adam carefully positioning the chute. Their team was called the Outlaws.

Jamie and Jesse's friendship continued into high school. At the end of middle school, they attended the traditional and ceremonial eighth grade semi-formal dance together. She recalls this as one of the fondest memories she has of her middle school years, a time which many so often wish to erase, but somehow made better for her because of her friendship with Jesse.

Unfortunately, prior to their freshman year, their school went through a redistricting change, resulting in Jamie having to attend a different high school than Jesse. Jamie recalls being so devastated by this change, she asked her parents to purchase a house in Jesse's town so they can still be in school together. School and life went on, and they still kept in touch and spent time together outside of school. Sadly, the following year Jesse passed away.

"I had a true connection with Jesse that I've never experienced with anyone else to this day," she recounts sadly, "Jesse was so handsome, he had a great sense of humor, he was smart, he was caring, he had a beautiful soul, and now, years later, I can honestly say that I've never had a friend quite like Jesse."

"Jesse Cooper was an honor roll student who loved to windsurf and write poetry. He also had severe cerebral palsy and was quadriplegic, unable to speak and wracked by seizures. He died suddenly at age seventeen."

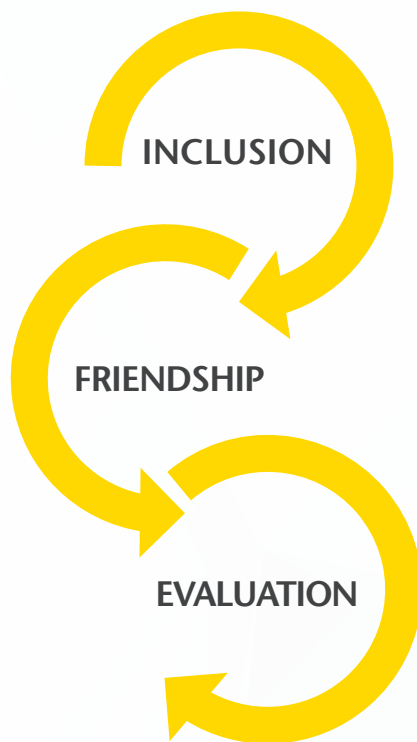
– From *Knowing Jesse* by Marianne Leone



Inclusion only happens when there is a commitment to systemic change. From an organizational level, change begins at the top. Be open, be involved, and be present.

This means your leadership team must be on board with the directives and goals of inclusion, must lead by example, and must invite everyone from the top down to share in the process from beginning to end. When all are mindful of and practicing inclusion, you begin to create a “climate of change” that will be sustainable, and where inclusion becomes part of the very definition of your organization. When inclusion is fully accomplished, then it will seem natural, and no one will need to call it “inclusion” anymore. But we will only get to that state of “natural,” or “it goes without saying,” by careful, conscious, consistent work. **Plan for the success of ALL by ALL.**

In fact, when organizations work toward implementing an authentic inclusive environment, there are actually more benefits to your organization. The benefits quickly outweigh any initial investments in training and support that you give your team to build your culture of inclusion.



What's next? When inclusion is achieved, it opens the minds of perceivers, so they can now see others as equals, fellow valued members of our community, sharing their gifts. Wow. Now there's an accomplishment!

But that's **not enough**. Once you arrive here on your journey, then the next step is bridging and nurturing those “acquaintances” into “friendships.”

? Let's think...

How might we take the next step, building upon inclusion to support the development of real friendship?

The Story of Norma & Phoebe

Phoebe and Norma are friends who originally met in 2011 through work, in which they discovered their shared love of yoga and strengthened their mutual special connection.

Although yoga was the original anchor to the growth of their friendship, they both enjoyed one another's company and would look forward to spending time together, simply hanging out on most weekends. In between their get-togethers, they kept each other updated on good news and everyday challenges. Norma has developmental disabilities, and up until the 2020 pandemic hit, she worked at her local Jewish Community Center (a job which Phoebe was instrumental in helping her to get) and is quite proud of her position there providing customer service as a ladies' locker room attendant.

Through the uncertainty experienced during the pandemic where many people (but especially those with disabilities) have experienced isolation and loneliness, Norma and Phoebe had each other to lean onto, to connect with and support through those challenging times. Updates and check-ins were consistent through email and Zoom; then, when able to do so, they got back to doing physically distanced yoga in Norma's yard again. Both are excited to say that when it is safe to do so again, they will be back at their favorite yoga studio in their community.

Norma recounts her favorite memory with Phoebe: "We used to do yoga at the studio before everything (COVID) and go out to



dinner. Now we do yoga in my back yard. We listen to our favorite music, do yoga, and talk about life." When asked what Phoebe's friendship means to her, she proudly shares, "She helped me get a job at the JCC. She cares about me. I love her."

Phoebe feels the same about having Norma in her life: "She is a light in this world and I feel honored she shares so much of her light with me."

As far as the future, both have something very special to look forward to. Phoebe will be celebrating her marriage (after the pandemic) and Norma will be there to support her and celebrate in her special day in an important and endearing role. Norma will be distributing bubbles to the guests and leading them in the creation of a cascade of bubbles as the happy couple exits the ceremony. Best of luck to Phoebe and Brian. And Norma, too.



HISTORY BOX

In our history box back on page 6, we noted that there were revolutionary changes over the past fifty years, in service patterns and in the lives of people with disabilities. The awful institutions are almost gone, and even some of the mistakes that were made in deinstitutionalization, like moving lots of people into nursing homes, are being un-done in many states. Nearly all people live in our communities, and gradually we have increased the inclusion of those people in community places and organizations.

But that has made it clear that inclusion, while it is a good thing in itself, is even more important as a step toward closer, more meaningful one-to-one friendship between people with and without disabilities. And that goal is still a long way off for most people with disabilities. Many families, for instance, have described how their daughter or son with disabilities has never been invited to the birthday party of a classmate. They are included in school, but not really friends, and you can imagine how sad that would be for the parents, and for the son or daughter.

We also can learn a lesson about inclusion and friendship from the 2020 COVID-19 pandemic. If your relationship with others in your community was entirely dependent upon being a gym member, or a church member, or a team-mate, or a regular at the cafe or sports bar, or a fellow-student in an evening class, then what happens when the gym or cafe or bar closes, the church suspends worship services, and all the classes are canceled or move online? Your inclusion leaves you still alone. The only way relationships will be sustained is if they have developed into one-to-one friendships.

So, our toolkit is taking on this next challenge, and inviting you to do the same. How might we invite and encourage real, freely given friendship?

Once in a while, it may happen by itself, "naturally." But often it takes some conscious intentionality, strategy, and steps taken by a person like you. Usually the person with a disability, even if they are fully able conversationally, may be shy, or may think of themselves as "taken care of" by staff or family. So, they may not make the first move. And usually the person without a disability has the same limitations; they may think they don't know how to interact with a person with a disability, or they may also think the person with a disability is "taken care of" by staff or family or by a segregated ("special") group. So, they may not "make the first move" either. It may be up to you.

Your Pathway Beyond Membership

Introduction

In general, you can hardly get to friendship without first taking the path through inclusion. Now that your commitment to inclusion is secure and you are supported by the recommended responses and best practices shared in the previous chapter, we enter the next step of your journey. On the path to friendship (or more precisely, creating a culture that supports the development of a friendship between two people, one with and one without a disability) this next leg of the journey poses more of a challenge or difficulty in imagining because, frankly, it hasn't happened often and so it is not as familiar.

We've come a long way already, but it is still only a mile marker, and it is not the end of the road. On to Friendship!

What is being suggested here is the beginning of a reciprocal, authentic friendship initiated from participation in a mutually desired activity. It is recognized that the initial work recommended may initially feel artificial in its nature, but the end result is to build a culture where it is more likely that an authentic, permanent relationship will be developed.



The Story of Sean & Sean

Sean M. and Sean C. met while participating in a church event five years ago. Sean M. has Down syndrome, and was 21 years old when they met. Admittedly, he was shy, so he was hanging out in the back of the room (something that is now difficult to imagine based on the gregarious and charming self-proclaimed former ladies' man interviewed for this story). Sean C. was very persistent in his attempts to get to know that shy young man and it paid off, leading to a fulfilling and meaningful friendship.

Since that initial meet-up, they've enjoyed exciting adventures together and are not only just best friends, but "bros." Some of their favorite activities are playing mini-golf and watching movies and football (Sean M. is an avid Chargers fan, while Sean C. roots for the Browns). In addition, Sean and Sean are great travel buddies as well, with Cancun and Las Vegas checked off their bucket list. In between getting together, they Facetime and text to stay connected.

As friends do, they have supported one another by being the best cheerleader, listening, and genuinely supporting each



other through their successes and life changing events. Sean C. was the one who supported and accompanied Sean M. to his final audition for a role on the TV Series *Born This Way*, an original documentary series which highlights the outgoing personalities and amazing abilities of seven young adults born with Down syndrome. Sean M. was selected for one of the roles and the story of his friendship with Sean C. is highlighted throughout the series.

Sean M. was not only Best Man at Sean C's wedding, but is also like an Uncle to his son Holden, who he lovingly brags "is the coolest kid. I love spending time with him, and he looks up to me." Likewise, Sean C. has reveled in his friend's success, celebrating with him on the launch of his own clothing line business, *Seanese*.

When asked what are the best attributes of their friendship, Sean M. boasts, "That's easy. He is like a brother to me, he has a place in my heart, and he means the world to me." Sean C. follows right behind him, responding, "He makes me laugh. He always has a bright outlook. I get so much out of our friendship, and I appreciate his perspective on life."

Sean C.'s advice to anyone who is looking to make a connection with someone else socially: "Seek out the person in the back of the room. It will be worth it".



Friendship: Let's Get Started

Let's consider this. Why is friendship so important, especially for persons with disabilities?

Someone may think, "Is there anyone in my life who sees me because they like me, not just because they're assigned to me?" A friendly acquaintance is not the same as having a real friend, and for a person with a disability, one without a disability is extraordinarily unusual. Likewise, the staff who serve people are not the same as friends. They are paid, and there often is a high turnover, so they come and go in the life of a person with a disability. If all you have is superficial acquaintances, and people that are paid to be with you, then there is a higher likelihood of experiencing loneliness.

Now we know where we are headed and why this is such important work. Let's take a moment to make this personal for you, the reader. Consider this question: What do your friends mean to you? Here are some of the things that people have said:



In fact, friendships can lead to jobs, new experiences, intimate relationships, or even a partner or spouse. Shouldn't everyone have the right to experience these things? We invite you to be part of a life-changing experience, to be an ambassador of friendships. Your role is to make it more likely (even if it can't be guaranteed) that two people may connect with each other based on a mutual interest they are participating in, a connection that leads to a **mutual, reciprocal, and authentic friendship**.

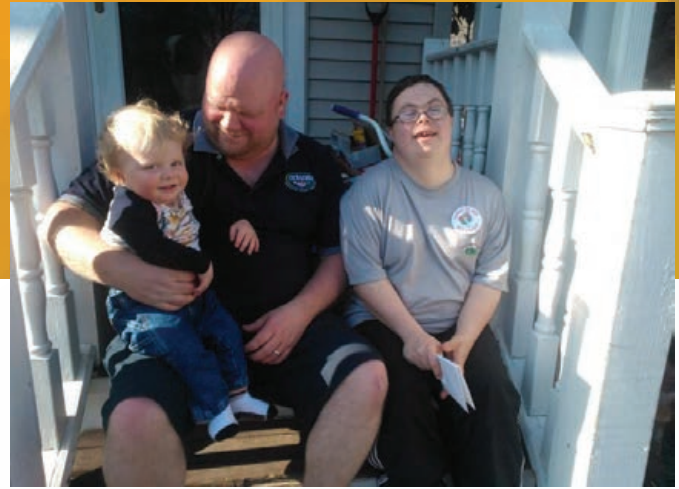
Once again, we will look at these hurdles through different lenses, differentiated by whom they affect most directly (staff, individuals/families, administration/organizations). By sharing these hurdles and responses, we can provide some concrete ways we can overcome these hurdles, and best practices that have helped people with disabilities to build new friendships.

With your path to inclusion in place, you have positioned yourself and your programming to help create the foundation of an authentic friendship between a person with, and a person without, a disability.

Let's start down this new pathway.

The Story of Matthew & Eric

Meet Matthew and Eric. They met as children playing in the neighborhood together. Matthew quotes the date as May 31, 1986, to be exact. Wiffleball, Kick The Can, and Ghost In The Graveyard were the neighborhood favorites. Eric recalls, "When Matty started playing with us, he was just one of the gang, included in every way." It wasn't until years later that he learned what Down syndrome was, while watching the TV series Life Goes On. "I never saw Matty as any different than the rest of us. I mean, we just had fun together."



Their friendship continued with time shared at each other's houses, watching their favorite TV show, Full House, and playing video games. When thinking about those years, Matthew recounts, "I loved spending time with Eric. His jokes were so funny that he made me laugh out loud."

As the years went on, Eric and Matthew continued to share in each other's lives like true best friends. Pizza night has become a favorite tradition, as well as the occasional visits to the pub. They are there for each other to share in special occasions as well, of course. Eric was present for graduation and other achievements to celebrate with Matthew. And Matthew was the Best Man at Eric's wedding and the Godfather to one of his children – as you can see in the photograph.

Eric describes their friendship: "Matty is more than my best friend, he is a part of my family." Matthew responds, "Eric always remembers my birthday, which is April 8 by the way. We will always be buddies; he's been in my life forever."





Hurdles Encountered by Program Staff*

We recognize there are hurdles that are, or may be, experienced by staff who have a responsibility to run programs or offerings for our community.

Because authentic friendships between persons with, and persons without, disabilities are somewhat rare, much of what is shared here may be speculative in nature and may have only a few examples to draw from. All great movements must begin somewhere and we must remember this movement is in its infancy.

*The term "staff" could refer to counselors, coaches, volunteers, instructors or anyone who is directly involved with running programs or offerings and also interfaces with the community membership.

LACK OF TRAINING/KNOWLEDGE

Does not have experience in or knowledge about how to facilitate information, resulting in a social relationship that cannot develop.

"I'm not comfortable trying to connect two people to be friends, especially where one has a disability and I've never worked with people with disabilities before."

MISUNDERSTANDING PROFESSIONAL ROLES

Staff may feel that supporting relationships is somehow crossing professional boundaries. They may believe this crossover is not appropriate or part of their role as an instructor (staff, coach, or teacher).

"I am a Zumba instructor, not a match maker."

LACK OF INITIATION DOES NOT = LACK OF INTEREST

Sometimes people may come into a class with limited experiences. Perhaps taking a class and exploring opportunities for freely-given relationships within a community is brand new. Just because someone doesn't initiate or reciprocate friendship opportunities in the same way, doesn't mean they don't want to be friends. They just may need more encouragement and support to do so.

"I've tried to introduce Peter to another person in class before, and he didn't seem interested. I don't think he cares about making friends."

LIMITED EXAMPLES = SPECULATION

The fact that this concept is highly speculative may be in fact a hurdle as well. For some, not having examples to draw upon may bring up hesitations around creating opportunities for friendships.

"I'm not really sure it is plausible to think about these two becoming friends. I mean, I've never seen a friendship like this before."

OVERUSE OF THE TERM "FRIENDS" – LANGUAGE MATTERS

When instructing a group, often those in charge may tend to over-use the term "friends." Limit the use to when there is a natural and organic connection and mutual interest occurring between two individuals. Instead use terms like teammate, players, congregation members, when referring to an entire group.

"Say hello to your ~~friends~~ teammates, everyone."



Overcoming Hurdles: Responses to Support Program Staff*

Explore these tips and strategies to provide program staff the tools and confidence to create a culture for friendships to develop between persons with, and without, disabilities.

*The term “staff” could refer to counselors, coaches, volunteers, instructors or anyone who is directly involved with running programs or offerings and also interfaces with the community membership.

INVEST IN AN ATMOSPHERE FOR FRIENDSHIP TO DEVELOP

It should become part of your organization’s goals and procedures. Staff, coaches, instructors, deacons, and volunteers should be provided the expectations and training to support the development of a friendship between a person with, and a person without, a disability.

JOIN THEIR TEAM TO PROBLEM-SOLVE TOGETHER

Build rapport with families or support staff to earn and increase trust and confidence. Be transparent. Reach out to them to provide solid communication on what steps you are taking, and hurdles you have experienced.

ADD OR IMPROVE SOCIAL SKILLS LESSONS

Create intentional teaching around personal space, boundaries, and social skills in real life settings.

USE LANGUAGE THAT DESCRIBES FRIENDSHIP

Some people could benefit from hearing stories that describe a budding friendship emerging. “It looks like you are becoming friends” can provide an invitation to the next step. Language creates reality and reality creates culture.

PROVIDE EXAMPLES OF FRIENDSHIPS

Supply books and/or movies that are available for members, which exhibit friendships between persons with and without disabilities. Be sure to evaluate them first to ensure their message is aligned and accurate. Include similar photos in marketing pieces or in wall art throughout your facility.

FIND YOUR BALANCE OF PROFESSIONALISM

A healthy balance of facilitating and supporting relationships can enhance the activity and foster friendships. Activities for recreation and leisure can bring a lot of fun, but we also want to look deeper, beyond the activity. Consider all interactions within your specific role (as staff) - who can you help this person become?

START YOUNG

Facilitating social connectedness between a child with, and a child without, a disability with your younger membership. We recognize that this type of guidance and support can be more comfortable to facilitate and likely to produce positive responses.

OFFER OPPORTUNITIES FOR LEARNING

Provide literature/resources for those who would like to learn more (community members, parents, staff and volunteers too).

PROVIDE SPECIALIZED TRAINING

Reach out to an inclusion trainer with experience in disability inclusion into community or recreational programs (see page 52).

Hurdles Encountered by Community Members* Who May Be Seeking to Connect Socially with Others Participating in Your Offering

We recognize there are hurdles that are specific to a person with disabilities and their family members/support network seeking to participate in recreation or community offerings with a goal of finding friendship with another member/participant. However, there may also be hurdles experienced or created by/for persons without disabilities and/or their family members.

*The term "COMMUNITY MEMBERS" could include persons with and without disabilities who participate in programming, as well as their family members and/or their direct support professionals.

MEANINGFUL PARTICIPATION IS NOT ALWAYS OBTAINED BY ALL MEMBERS

Intentional work must be put in by all involved to ensure that participants with disabilities are participating in meaningful ways with valued roles. If this is not achieved, it decreases the probability for friendships with other members/participants to occur.

"I'd like to get to know Sarah better, but she always shows up for class late and then her staff is waiting by the door, rushing her out as soon as class is over."

PEOPLE JOINING IN AS A GROUP, NOT INDIVIDUALLY

Participating in activities in large groups (such as a group home) does not encourage facilitating connections. It must be done very individually to build one relationship, two people at a time.

"There are four women that come to my church each week with their staff. I know they are from a group home, but I haven't gotten to know anyone, because they come as a group and stick to themselves."

OVERCOMING STIGMA OR STEREOTYPES

Sometimes people with disabilities are seen by community members with an implicit bias that defines them as "client." Even well-intended people may treat others differently, because they see their disability and not the person first.

"That person has autism; therefore, they must have staff that accompanies them."

FACILITATION MAY FEEL UNNATURAL

Providing support in facilitating the development of a friendship between any two people may feel unnatural. If it happened naturally, we wouldn't be here today! That kind of facilitation will almost always need intentionality.

"This seems like a lot of work for something that we all know isn't going to work out."

INDIVIDUALS SEEKING FRIENDS COME ON TOO STRONG

People may experience loneliness regularly and may be desperate to create friendships. Their efforts may appear as too strong or intrusive. This can result in others being more guarded.

"I can't believe that Mary is giving her phone number to everyone in the group and asking to friend them on Facebook."



Overcoming Hurdles: Responses to Support Community Members* Seeking Friendship and Their Families

Explore these tips and strategies to provide individuals with disabilities and their families a welcoming and supportive environment where they can access opportunities that can help them become valued members of the community. Recognize that members without disabilities and their families have a key role in creating a culture of inclusion.

*The term “COMMUNITY MEMBERS” could include persons with and without disabilities who participate in programming, as well as their family members and/or their direct support professionals.

SET PEOPLE UP FOR SUCCESS

Encourage families or support staff to talk about social norms and what will be expected for the environment in advance. Role play and encourage connections. Don't disrupt any communication attempt to publicly correct behavior, if in fact it is not dangerous and does not pose any threat.

JOIN THEIR TEAM TO PROBLEM-SOLVE TOGETHER

Build rapport with families or support staff to earn and increase trust and confidence. Be transparent. Reach out to them to provide suggestions and approaches that will help this person to be successful in your program.

COMMUNICATE EFFECTIVELY WITH FAMILY MEMBERS

Let families or parents know if their children are playing well together to encourage outside of school connections (especially regarding children with a communication disorder).

STRENGTHEN THE SUPPORT NETWORK

With school age children, connect with an advocate at school to create a strong support network.



GIVE TALKING POINTS TO MEMBERS

Provide literature/resources to those who would like to learn more (community members, parents, staff and volunteers too).

SAY HELLO WITH A SMILE!

Social niceties go a long way toward opening the door to communication and relationship building (and can also decrease social anxiety). Say hello, be friendly, and introduce yourself.

EMPOWER INFORMATION SHARING AND EDUCATION

Engage the help of members with disabilities to create sources of information about their disability. With the families' permission, for example, create a newsletter to send home to other parents to learn about autism.

RECRUIT A WELCOMING INSIDER

Do you know someone in the group that you could ask to welcome this person in? Who is a natural leader or extrovert – or has particularly shown to be welcoming?
Seek someone within your network to take charge and do outreach ahead of time.

ENCOURAGE MEANINGFUL PARTICIPATION

Set expectations for group home staff or family to come early and stay late for activities. Before and after class time provides valuable socialization opportunities.
Help build relationships so people get to know one another as equal participating members, by name, and by shared interests.

HELP A NEW MEMBER BE MORE AT EASE

If a person has anxiety about trying something new, invite them to visit/ tour prior to the first class to build confidence and familiarity.

Hurdles Encountered by Program Leadership or Your Organization as a Whole

We do know of organizations (and maybe even your organization) which have been able to include people with disabilities successfully. We also know, however, that even those examples show us that the next step remains to be taken. We need to create an organizational culture with the mechanisms that not only fully include people with disabilities, but encourage and help to sustain one to one friendship. What would such an organizational culture look like?

Put yourself in this picture.

You are a leader within your YMCA, Church, Recreation Program, or Community Center, and have made the decision to more intentionally create a culture where authentic and reciprocal friendships between persons with and without disabilities can be developed and fostered. Perhaps you've heard about such a friendship that has evolved between two of your members, and you recognize the benefits and values for all within your community. As you go through the process of bringing this initiative to fruition, some hurdles start to develop, that may look like the following.

MISPERCEPTION OF INCLUSION

A narrow view or understanding exists of what inclusion truly means - there is a traditional focus on a human service-centered relationship approach, which in fact is segregated.

"We offer so many fun activities for that population, plenty of opportunities for them to make friends, like our sensory swim or adapted story time social."

"Certainly they have lots of friends at their day program."

RESISTANCE AROUND ROLES OR RESPONSIBILITIES

Society focuses so deeply on the "their own staff" mindset, meaning people with disabilities have traditionally been "taken care of" by staff who are paid to assist them. Therefore, encouraging friendships is seen as not within the scope of service or the responsibility of the general public.

"They are a welcomed member at our club, and they have a care worker that we even allow to come for free. The trained staff take care of what they need, so it's not our place to get involved."



FAILURE TO RECOGNIZE YOUR MEMBERSHIP'S INTENT

Members may be seeking membership primarily for the social aspects, not just personal fitness or hearing a rousing sermon or adding to their lifetime birding list, etc.

"Everyone is so busy they just want to get in and out of class and wouldn't have time for this type of thing."

PRIORITIZATION, OR LACK THEREOF

There isn't buy-in or a sense of prioritization from your leadership team, staff members, or the community as a whole.

"We aren't funded for that. We don't have the money, time, and resources to explore a specialized friend-seeking effort."

? Let's think...

These same hurdles are parallel to those that emerged years ago when the initial concept of inclusion was being introduced in community organizations around the country. These hurdles were overcome then, continue to be overcome now, and with thoughtful approaches, collaboration, and commitment, will be overcome as well, resulting in sustainable authentic one-to-one friendships.

Overcoming Hurdles: Responses to Support Program Leadership of Your Organization as a Whole

Now that we've had a look at what hurdles your organization may encounter, what can be done? You want to be intentional in your work, so what steps can your organization take? What processes can be in place to be more preventative in your practices? Perhaps it would be helpful to consider these responses.

By now, you understand that any type of systemic change (like we are proposing here for friendship) takes organizational commitment. Leadership must be on board with the directives and goals of this initiative. Lead by example and invite everyone from the top down to share in the process from beginning to end. Your program explores or engages in these practices as preventative action, anticipating possible hurdles.

SET CLEAR GOALS

Focus on your social inclusion efforts in your strategic plan as a first critical step towards the "next level" within your organization. By making this a priority, you can set larger, long-term goals that align directly with your mission. Likewise, smaller goals along the way will engage and raise awareness of everyone's responsibility to contribute to this effort at all levels, changing culture over time.

OFFER SPECIALIZED TRAINING

As part of your inclusion training, offer specialized guidance on facilitation of friendships to your staff and teams. Additionally, training should be available so that current members can act as "welcomers" and mentors for all new members, while also providing for best ways to do that with people with disabilities.

ENSURE BOARD DIVERSITY

Bring diversity into an Inclusion Advisory Committee and Board of Directors. Ensure persons with disabilities (and other groups) are represented and involved as members.

SEARCH, SEEK & ASK!

Don't be shy or afraid to seek support or resources from advisory boards or private donors to help launch the effort to bring people with and without disabilities together.

UNDERSTAND PEOPLE'S NEEDS

Understand that many of your members—not just people with disabilities—may need a little “extra” so they can meaningfully connect with other members. Not all people are extroverts and sometimes require someone to tactfully initiate that first step or break the ice.

CREATE A SENSE OF BELONGING

Almost everyone would like to really belong. The 2020 Coronavirus pandemic certainly magnified that for people with disabilities. Organizations should recognize this in their very visible and transparent mission statement that one of their intentions is to authentically connect people with each other.

PARTNER UP

Collaborate with a human service organization, inviting them to embed staff knowledgeable in your activities to work from your facility/space. Do not have them be responsible just for people with disabilities, but their presence can help guide efforts to connect all of your various members.

INCLUDE “FRIENDSHIP” ORGANIZATION-WIDE

Be sure to include friendship as an element for all staff orientation, within job descriptions, and performance appraisals. There is no over-use of this term.

A final note on Inclusion and pathways to friendship

Some organizations, like many churches and some other establishments, encourage members to reach out to each other in helpful ways outside of the actual organization's activities. For example, church members often give rides and supply meals to members in need. Other associations may not actively encourage and connect their members. In either situation, think about what you (in your role) can do to create or facilitate an absolute relationship/friendship.

A simple way to approach your organization's commitment to this is to pose the question inward. "How might we create a new legacy.....for our organization...for our members with disabilities and their families, for ourselves and for our communities?" or "How are we fulfilling our mission? Are our actions aligned with our purpose?"

In closing, I would like to share with each of you a few sentiments about what this journey of researching and composing this tool-kit has meant to me. It has been a pure joy, but it has also been eye-opening. Despite widespread awareness of the importance and benefits of friendship, I've recognized through this process that people with and without disabilities still infrequently develop authentic reciprocal friendships, even in inclusive settings. This was one of the many reasons that ignited my desire to write this toolkit. I recognize that this project was certainly enhanced by the great guidance and generous contributions of many.

My heartfelt thanks to Jack Yates, who has been a tremendous support, from conception to the final edits. It has been a pure pleasure and honor to have Jack's wisdom, knowledge, and insight to draw upon. What he has shared with me will last far past this project and undoubtedly shape my work and mission moving forward.

My grateful appreciation to Mary Wrenn-Woodward, for your willingness to be my sounding board, and my personal editor! Your assistance went way beyond providing copyedit, as your perspective of not having experience at all with the world of inclusion or disabilities provided me the necessary lens for my intended audience - to make it understandable for all readers.

To my *Pathways to Friendship* colleagues and advisory board members, who are pioneers in this work, I am fortunate to have had the opportunity to tap into your vast experience and knowledge. Thank you, Jim Ross, Katie Driscoll, Phoebe Goodman, and Tom Doody for lending your support, and to Leo Sarkissian, Executive Director of The Arc of Massachusetts, for your recognition of the value of the direction of this toolkit, and for entrusting me with this important message.

Providing examples of authentic and thriving friendships was a crucial part of the reader's experience. It was a complete honor and humbling opportunity to meet and interview the friends who shared their stories throughout this book. My heart was touched by each and every one of their stories, by their passion, by their love for each other, and by their demonstration of the meaning of friendship.

To my dedicated colleagues, recreation professionals, and community members who took the time to meet and share your experiences around the hurdles and successes you've encountered within your organizations as you advocate for inclusion. Thank you Chenine Peloquin, Katie DeAngelis, Evelyn Hausslein, Kate Quinn, Rebekah Coffey, Serah Selmon, Joe Leaver, Sue Woodward, Micah Barshay, Sydney Lahmeyer, Kerri Sadoff, and Lauren Rodday. And to parents Melissa Winchell, Emily Colson and Marianne Leone for sharing your personal stories which have each impacted me, my vision, and my drive, not just for this project, but for the entire mission of my work.

And thank you (yes, you!) for taking this journey, for recognizing that you hold the power to make an impact on friendships between persons with, and persons without, disabilities, and for arming yourself with the tools laid out here, so that you can go out there and make a difference!

*Lisa Drennan,
MERGE Diverse Abilities Inclusion Consulting*



Lisa Drennan is the founder of MERGE Diverse Abilities Inclusion Consulting, providing staff training and expert consultation to recreation, sport, camp, and community organizations on how to be inclusive of people with diverse abilities. Additionally, MERGE is available for coaching and consultation to agencies supporting people with disabilities to be valued members of their community. For assistance with your organization, please visit: www.mergeconsulting.org or contact Lisa by email at lisadrennan@mergeconsulting.org or phone 781.724.1918.



Now it's your turn:

Use this space to take notes on your organization's steps toward a *Pathway to Friendship*.

What are the hurdles and the ways to overcome those hurdles for your staff, community or organization?



A series of horizontal lines for writing, overlaid on a background of light gray geometric shapes.




The Arc[™]
Massachusetts

The Arc of Massachusetts
217 South Street
Waltham, MA 02453

tel. 781-891-6270
www.arcmass.org

